

03

Extracting Angles from Existing Copy

Document 3 of 9

This document extends **Finding Your Angle**. Read that document first — it defines angle statements, the three questions, the recurring angle families, and the awareness stages this workflow relies on.

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Why Mine the Page First

Finding Your Angle established that angles can come from anywhere, and that every angle must answer three questions: who exactly it's for, what on the page pays it off, and why the reader hasn't already walked past it. This document teaches the single most reliable *generator* of angles — mining the advertorial and sales page you're already promoting — and why it's the right first move on nearly every campaign.

Two reasons. First, the material is **pre-proven** — meaning those pages were already researched, written, and (if the offer is running at scale) tested with real ad spend before you arrived. The writer packed the advertorial with claims, stories, mechanisms, and proof points, and each one is a potential doorway. Your job as the ad buyer isn't to out-write that page; it's to **mine it**. Second, angles mined from the page arrive with the first half of **Question 2** built in: an idea extracted from the page is, by definition, already *in* the page the click lands on. (Whether the page pays it off *proportionally* still needs checking — more on that below.)

Be clear about what this workflow is and isn't. It is a generator — the fastest, safest one you have. It is **not the only place angles come from**, and it doesn't excuse any angle from the three questions: a mined angle still needs its specific reader (Question 1) and still has to be a doorway this reader hasn't walked past forty times already (Question 3 — which is exactly where a saturated offer's most obvious gold lines fail). And Question 1 is working *during* the mining, not after: which lines read as gold depends entirely on who you're reading for. A line about cost is gold for a reader pricing alternatives and filler for a reader who doesn't yet believe the problem exists.

One thing this workflow does **not** do: write headlines. The output of extraction is an **angle list** — angle statements, deduplicated and stage-tagged. Headline writing is a separate act that comes afterward, several headlines per angle, using Documents 1, 7, and 8. Keep the wall up.

Gold Lines: The Raw Material

A **gold line** is any line in the advertorial or sales page that could carry an ad on its own. You'll recognize one by the reaction it provokes: it makes a sharp claim, tells a human moment, names a villain, quantifies a saving, or reveals who's behind the product. Gold lines are concrete and specific; filler lines are abstract and interchangeable. Treat "gold line" as a convenient working label for the highlighting step — as you'll see next, page evidence includes whole passages as well as single lines.

Two things a gold line is *not*:

- **A gold line is not an angle yet.** A typical advertorial yields five to fifteen gold lines, but those lines usually contain only three to five genuinely different angles — because good advertorials hammer their central idea from many directions. Mistaking every gold line for its own angle is the single most common extraction error, and the sorting steps below exist to catch it.
- **Gold lines are not the only place page angles live.** Some angles are carried by the page's *arc* — the sequence of problem, discovery, and solution the page walks the reader through — rather than by any quotable sentence. Think of the long build of frustration before the reveal, or the unnamed villain the whole page circles. Those are real angles, and they pass Question 2 the same way: you point at the *passage* that pays them off instead of a single line. Quotable lines are the strongest evidence of payoff, not the definition of it — when a page pays a sentiment off substantively, it almost always produces quotable lines along the way. If you find yourself claiming an angle with no line *and* no passage to point at, that's the warning sign: you've stopped extracting and started inventing.

The Extraction Workflow

Work through the advertorial top to bottom, then the sales page — reading as your specific reader, not as yourself: the person you named in Question 1, not the media buyer holding the highlighter. Five steps, and notice that headline writing is not one of them.

1. **Highlight the gold lines.** Read line by line and mark every sentence that would make *your reader* feel something specific or learn something concrete — and record the *exact quote*. Ignore transitions, introductory filler, and generic benefit talk. If an idea grips you

but no single line carries it, note the passage that does — an anchor is required either way, because the anchor is your Question 2 answer.

2. **Name the big idea.** For each highlight, write the idea in three words or fewer: *hidden failure, inventor's story, saves money, new mechanism*. If you can't name it that tightly, it isn't a gold line — it's two ideas tangled together, or none.
3. **Sort with the families — loosely.** Try each big idea against the recurring families from **Finding Your Angle** (Story, Warning, Discovery/News, Contrarian, Local, Unique Mechanism, Transformation, Social Proof/Authority) or flag it as a **benefit lead**. The families are a loose sorting aid here, not a test: an idea that fits no family but would still make your reader click is **still an angle** — keep it, named in plain words. (Remember from Document 2: unclassifiable might mean unfenced, and unfenced might be your edge.) What you set aside at this step are lines that aren't doorways at all — statistics, credentials, and guarantees *when they're playing a supporting role*. Those become proof material for supporting copy later. But watch for the exception: if a statistic or credential creates its own distinct reason to care for your specific reader, it's a candidate angle — keep it on the list.
4. **Merge the duplicates.** This is the step that turns gold lines into angles, and the step most often skipped. The rule: **two entries that express the same underlying idea are one angle wearing two outfits** — merge them into a single angle statement and keep the strongest source quotes attached as proof material. The family labels help you *spot* merge candidates (entries that sorted into the same family deserve a hard look), but the test is always the idea, not the label — two Warning-family entries can be genuinely different doorways, and one idea can hide under two different labels. An advertorial's central thesis will typically show up in four or five gold lines dressed as its mechanism, its myth-busting, its diagnosis, and its analogy; after merging, that's *one* angle. A list that survives this step honestly is short. Short is correct.
5. **Flag the congruency lift, then run the three questions.** Two finishing moves:
 - The advertorial's **own headline** (or lead claim) goes on your list as angle #1, labeled the **congruency lift** — the maximum-scent baseline. Strictly speaking it isn't a new angle at all; it's the purest execution of "one angle running the whole route," with zero translation loss. It's your comparison baseline: the reference every other angle

is trying to beat, and usually worth testing in its own right where the platform and offer allow.

- Then put every surviving angle through Document 2's three questions. Question 1: name its specific reader and awareness stage — warnings and stories toward the unaware, discovery toward the problem-aware, mechanism and contrarian toward the burned-and-skeptical. Question 2's first half is built in for mined angles, but check *proportionality*: mention is not payoff, and a doorway the page only gestures at is still a bait. Question 3: check the doorway against what's already running on this offer — the most obvious gold line on a scaling offer is usually the most saturated one.

The output: a deduplicated, source-anchored, stage-tagged **angle list**. Only now do you move to headlines — several competing headlines per angle, never one headline per gold line.

Worked Example: Mining the ClearSpring Advertorial

Take the fictional ClearSpring water filter from **Finding Your Angle**, and suppose its advertorial contains these lines (condensed, gold lines in bold):

"The Filter Pitcher In Your Fridge May Be Doing Almost Nothing — Here's What It Misses." Municipal reports list dozens of trace compounds standard pitchers were never designed to catch...

"Your pitcher isn't broken — it was never built for this job in the first place." The carbon pouch inside was designed decades ago for taste, not for what's in the water today...

Frank Delano spent thirty-one years fixing pipes before he retired. **"I've seen the inside of this city's water mains. I wouldn't drink from my own tap — so I built something."**

Traditional whole-home filtration systems run into the thousands, plus installation.

"ClearSpring delivers the same three-stage filtration for less than a monthly water-jug habit."

The secret is the sequence: sediment, carbon, then a ceramic micro-barrier — **"a three-stage path the water walks in order, each stage catching what the last one can't."**

Running the workflow: five gold lines, five big ideas (*hidden failure, wrong tool, inventor's story, saves money, named mechanism*). Sorting and merging produces the angle list:

Angle 1 — Congruency lift (baseline). The advertorial's own headline, run nearly verbatim. Family: Warning. *Your current filter is quietly failing and you've never been shown what it misses.* Awareness: unaware/problem-unaware.

Angle 2 — The wrong-tool truth. Gold lines 1 and 2 wear different clothes — one reads as a Warning, the other as a Contrarian myth-bust — but strip the outfits and they express the **same underlying idea**: *the pitcher was never built for this job*. So they **merge into one angle**, with both quotes kept as proof material. Awareness: problem-aware. Note what the merge caught — and how it caught it: not because the two lines shared a family label (they didn't sort identically), but because the idea underneath was one idea. Without step 4, they'd masquerade as two angles.

Angle 3 — The insider who built his own. Frank's quote. Family: Story + Unique Mechanism — the classic inventor stack. *A tradesman who saw the problem from the inside refused to live with it and built the fix himself.* Awareness: product-aware/skeptical (his trade is the proof).

Angle 4 — Costs less than the habit. The jug-habit comparison. A **benefit lead** — no family name required, and none needed, as long as it's labeled honestly. Awareness: solution-aware readers already pricing alternatives.

Angle 5 — The named mechanism. The three-stage path. Family: Unique Mechanism. *There's a specific, named sequence behind this — and it's the reason pitchers miss what this catches.* Awareness: solution-aware, burned-before.

And there's one more angle here that no single line contains — a **passage-anchored** angle, carried by a stretch of the page rather than a quote. The advertorial's whole first half is an ordinary household slowly discovering that the thing they trusted was never doing the job. For a reader who prides herself on running a careful home, *you did everything right*

and were failed anyway is a real doorway. Its anchor is not a quote but the entire opening arc, which pays it off in full. Call it **Angle 6 — Did everything right, failed anyway.**

Family: Warning + Story. Awareness: unaware.

Five gold lines in; six angles out — five line-anchored (after the merge collapsed two of six candidates into one) and one passage-anchored. On a real advertorial, expect ten or more gold lines to reduce to four or five angles. Each of these angle statements now goes through the three questions, then on to headline work: several competing headlines per angle, written with Documents 1, 7, and 8 — that step happens after this document ends, not inside it.

■ Calibrating: Extraction With an AI Assistant

Today, much of this workflow runs through AI: you hand an assistant your advertorial and sales page and ask it for angles. That's a fine way to work — the AI is an accelerator for this workflow, and for audience and market research too — but left to itself, an AI makes one predictable error: **it returns your gold lines dressed up as angles.** Ask for ten angles and you'll get ten confident entries with ten different labels — and when you look for the ideas underneath, half of them collapse into the same doorway restated as its mechanism, its myth, its diagnosis, and its analogy. Ten angles on the page; four in reality. A member who tests all ten is paying to run the same angle against itself — wasteful not because a winning angle can never support multiple expressions, but because you learn nothing new from the duplicate spend.

The workflow above is your audit of the machine — your own manual check of the AI's list against the page — and note what you're checking for: **distinct underlying ideas, each anchored to the page.** You are *not* checking whether the AI used approved family names; its labels are usually made up on the spot, and that's fine — labels are cheap. Ideas are what you count.

- **Demand anchors.** Every angle the assistant proposes must point at what pays it off — an exact quoted line, or a named passage. No anchor means the machine invented it, and an invented angle has no congruence behind it until *you* find its payoff on the page.

- **Count ideas, not entries.** For each proposal, name the underlying idea in three words or fewer, then apply step 4's rule out loud: same underlying idea = merge, whatever the labels say. This is the step the AI skips on its own, and the step that turns its raw output into an honest angle list. Ten entries collapsing to four ideas is the normal outcome, not a failure.
- **Demand the lift.** If the batch doesn't include the page's own headline labeled as the congruency-lift baseline, add it yourself — the baseline belongs on every list. (Watch for the sneaky version: the AI often *does* include the page's headline — as just another "angle," unlabeled. Catch it and name it.)
- **Make it answer the three questions.** Specific reader and awareness stage for each angle, proportional payoff on the page, and a freshness check against what's already running. An angle list without those answers is a list you don't know how to test.
- **You keep the judgment.** The assistant can highlight and sort faster than you can — but *which* doorway fits your reader is a call only you can calibrate against your own results.

✓ Key Takeaways

- Mining the page is the **most reliable generator** of angles — pre-proven material that arrives already anchored to the page — but it is a generator, not the only source, and its output still faces all three questions, including proportional payoff.
- Don't out-write the advertorial — **mine it**, reading as your specific reader, not as yourself.
- A **gold line** is not an angle, and gold lines are not the only page angles: passage-anchored angles (the arc, the unnamed villain) are real — quotable lines are the strongest *evidence* of payoff, not the definition of it. No line and no passage to point at = you're inventing, not extracting.
- The workflow: highlight (with exact quotes or named passages) → name the big idea → sort loosely with the families → **merge duplicates** (same underlying idea

= one angle, whatever the labels) → flag the congruency lift and run the three questions.

- The **congruency lift** — the page's own headline as your comparison baseline — leads every angle list, honestly labeled.
- The output of extraction is an **angle list**, not headlines. Headlines come afterward: several per angle, per Documents 1, 7, and 8. Keep the wall up.
- When AI does the extracting, your audit counts **ideas, not entries**: anchors for every proposal, forced merges on the same underlying idea, a labeled lift, and three-questions answers.